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Bus company faces personal injury claims

Transdev named in at least 15 lawsuits since it began transporting BPS students

By John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

Gloria Caldwell was walking along Woodrow Avenue in Dorchester when the Boston Public Schools bus approached at a fast clip, jumping the sidewalk as it made a right turn onto Milton Avenue.

Caldwell's right foot was crushed, her bones fractured under the vehicle, Caldwell later said in her personal injury case filed at Suffolk Superior Court.

Caldwell's case is among 15 personal injury claims against transportation company Transdev, and its drivers, since it began operating BPS school buses in 2013, according to a review

of personal injury claims on file at Suffolk Superior Court.

Among the allegations: A Transdev driver, on his first day on the job, crashed a bus into the back of a car while looking at a clipboard in 2019; after a Transdev driver exited a BPS bus, the unattended bus rolled uncontrolled across a parking lot in 2015, striking a BPS assistant principal, shattering his pelvis; and another Transdev driver crashed a BPS bus into a vehicle during a police stop in 2022.

Most recently, Lens Arthur Joseph, a 5-year-old UP Academy Dorchester student, died on



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Lens Arthur Joseph, a 5-year-old UP Academy Dorchester student, was killed on April 28 in Hyde Park.

'Every day, thousands of families entrust BPS with their children's safety. We must ensure that trust is not misplaced.'

ERIN MURPHY,
city councilor at-large

Public defenders to limit workload

Dispute over pay could lead to crisis in courts as cases get sidetracked

By Sean Cotter
GLOBE STAFF

A large contingent of court-appointed lawyers is planning to stop taking new criminal cases beginning Tuesday as they push for higher pay, leaving the courts to grapple with the constitutional chaos that could follow if no lawyers are available to take on indigent defendants.

The appointed lawyers, called bar advocates, operate their legal work independently but sign up in local courts as available to take the cases of anyone facing criminal charges who, the courts deem, cannot afford a lawyer on their own. They are paid with public funds so the state can meet defendants' constitutional right to counsel.

Those who will no longer take cases, a contingent that spans the state, are joining dozens of others who have already left, saying they are paid low hourly rates that languish behind neighboring states.

"There's been this exodus that's creating a crisis," said Sean Delaney, a bar advocate in Middlesex and Barnstable counties, who says he will stop taking new cases starting Tuesday, when the courts reopen after the holiday weekend.

The loss of those lawyers could significantly hinder the court system. In Massachusetts, about 80 percent of people whom the courts deem indigent are represented by bar advocates. Staff attorneys employed full time by the state's public defender agency, called the Committee for Public

ATTORNEYS, Page A7

HARD LESSONS ON THE HORIZON

Trump's budget targets English learner, college transition programs



PHOTOS BY ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

First-graders are part of a dual language program at Gomes Elementary School in New Bedford.



Gomes principal Ellyn Gallant embraced a first-grade student. Cuts in the language program could lead to the loss of staff members.

By Christopher Huffaker and Marcela Rodrigues
GLOBE STAFF

NEW BEDFORD — Students at Alfred J. Gomes Elementary School didn't hesitate when teacher Natalia Gioni asked them to sing along.

"Somos como las flores, necesitamos la lluvia y el sol," the first-graders sang as they learned what plants need to grow and survive. Water, sunlight, and air, they told Gioni in Spanish.

As bilingualism is celebrated at the New Bedford school, Superintendent Andrew O'Leary is concerned President Trump's proposed budget for 2026 would eliminate federal funding that supports English language acquisition programs.

The \$890 million cut nationwide would translate to the loss of three or four staff members in New Bedford, where the district receives about half a million dollars for these programs.

"It would be the federal government turning its back on the community," O'Leary said.

Similar scenes are playing out across the state as school districts, higher education institutions, and education advocates grapple with the potential impact of billions in cuts proposed

SCHOOLS, Page A10

Move for more accountability of police slows

Five years after Floyd's death, officials scale back state's signature reforms

By Dan Glaun
GLOBE STAFF

Following waves of protest over the death of George Floyd in 2020, police reformers in Massachusetts saw an opportunity to bring unprecedented accountability and transparency to the state's law enforcement agencies, many of which handled complaints in secrecy and with little civilian oversight.

Five years later, political momentum has dropped, the federal government is walking away from reform deals and the state Legislature's signature reform achievement — the Peace Officer Standards and Training Commission, or POST — is scaling back its ambitions due to insufficient funding.

"We've made some significant progress on the transparency piece. We need to do more," said Sophia Hall, deputy litigation director for the Boston-based organization Lawyers for Civil Rights. "The accountability piece, I think, still needs a lot of work."

The killing of Floyd by a Minneapolis police officer and other cases of police brutality brought a reckoning over the nation's history of racism

POLICE, Page A7

Flag, rays, ceremony

Monday: Mostly sunny. High 61-66, low 51-56.
Tuesday: More sun, warmer. High 70-75, low 54-59.
Sunrise: 5:13. Sunset: 8:10.
Weather and comics, **D4-5**.
Obituaries, **C9**.

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As the standoff between Harvard and the Trump administration escalates, the institution's ability to attract students, and its standing on the global stage, seemingly hangs in the balance. **B1.**

The Army Corps of Engineers is in the midst of a study of the Boston shoreline to help it prepare for rising seas. **B1.**

Unraveling the mystery of the seemingly ever-rising cost of energy. **D1.**

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A homecoming, 81 years later

Extended family will receive body of aviator killed in World War II

By Michael E. Ruane
WASHINGTON POST

For many years after Second Lieutenant Thomas V. Kelly Jr. was killed in World War II, his parents kept his empty bedroom like a shrine to their only son.

In the local cemetery, they placed a memorial stone etched with his name and an image of his Army Air Forces bomber. His body had been lost when the plane was shot down and sank to the bottom of the Pacific Ocean.



Bombardier Thomas Kelly Jr. (right), with navigator Donald Sheppick.

► BU honors alumni killed in service. B3.

Kelly was 21. His mother, Theresa, saved his letters, including one that arrived weeks after his death. When his mother, father, Thomas Sr., and sister, Betty, died, they were laid to rest by his stone.

On Memorial Day, 81 years after he was killed off New Guinea, and two years after his remains were recovered from the underwater crash site, Kelly is to be buried beside his family in Livermore, Calif.

The burial is the culmination of a 12-year search by his relatives, launched on Memorial Day 2013, that was joined by the Navy, the Defense POW/MIA Accounting Agency, and the

AIRMAN, Page A5